

TECH CHOICES



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Conchango Leads In The Field Of European Web Design Agencies

The Forrester Wave™ Vendor Summary, Q2 2006

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Conchango is a UK-based agency that stresses iterative design, client management skills, and lots of client face time to resolve issues. The agency has an articulated set of mostly high-touch collaboration tactics that include sharing personas, user testing results, and case studies with technology and branding partners as a way to align goals. Reference sites received top marks for user experience and strong scores for Brand Image, making this agency suitable for any type of engagement.

TARGET AUDIENCE

Customer Experience Executive, Brand or Advertising Executive, and Interactive Marketing Executive

CONCHANGO IS SUITED TO ONE AND ALL

Conchango is a medium-size vendor with 200 full-time equivalents in its design practice and two full-service offices in the UK. Its portfolio includes work for Marks & Spencer, HMV, Virgin Atlantic, Boots, and Lloyds of London.

Forrester evaluated Conchango's current offering and strategy against 18 criteria, including the overall scores of two reference sites; we evaluated these using both Forrester's Web Site Review and Brand Image Review methodologies (see Figure 1).¹ Overall, the vendor's reference work is very strong in user experience and strong in Brand Image. The agency is an especially good fit for buyers who want:

- **Help with creating personas and value an iterative design approach.** Conchango uses personas as a standard tool in its design process. It creates its personas with accurate user research, checks them according to a persona builder matrix, and, as a best practice, displays the personas in the studio during the design process to align the design team. The agency works according to "The Agile Process," which focuses on close involvement and frequent communication between the developer team and business experts, early return on investment, and software development through iterative delivery steps. This includes multiple rounds of user testing during the design cycle, which increases the likelihood that flaws are found *before* the site is up and running.²
- **A single company that delivers strong user experience and Brand Image in one go.** Conchango has very strong practices in conducting primary user research and does thorough usability testing, which shows in the ease of use of their sites. The agency's brand-focused creativity is also strong,

making the vendor a great pick for companies that want to build usable sites but convey a consistent brand statement at the same time. On top of that, firms can rely on the agency for products beyond the Web, such as its experience in designing interactive kiosks.³

To see how Conchango stacks up against nine other competitors, see the Forrester Wave™ evaluation of the European Web design agency market.⁴

Figure 1 Conchango Evaluation Overview

CURRENT OFFERING	
User research	Conchango consistently conducts in-depth research using an array of methodologies. It performs ethnographic research like listening in on customer service calls in the contact center and observing and interviewing customers in the field. It also uses mobile testing tools to make recordings of usability testing sessions for clients to view. Conchango involves clients by requiring them to sign off on every stage of the project.
Persona creation	Conchango developed a “persona builder matrix” based on sociodemographic categories, traits, and objectives. Personas are written in narrative format, focus on enabling design decisions (complete and tight), call out key attributes and high-level goals, evoke empathy with rich details, and include a photo.
Persona application	The agency integrates personas broadly throughout the strategy and design processes. It also uses them to prioritize new content and functions and deploys post-launch analytics to validate personas. It recruits representative test participants using a matrix that matches them to the personality, demographics, and other traits of the personas. Conchango displays the personas in the studio during the design process.
Design process	Conchango uses a customer-centered approach to solution design. Relevant user research and testing is consistently integrated throughout the process and tied to post-launch measurement: from mock-up testing to post-launch usability testing.
Skill sets	Conchango’s staff includes user experience consultants, graphic designers, and digital brand specialists to give the agency a complete range of design skills and competence in applying primary user research and testing.
Collaboration abilities	The agency has an articulated set of mostly high-touch collaboration tactics that include sharing personas, user testing results, and case studies with technology and branding partners as a way to align goals. Conchango uses standard tools like a project portal. It stresses client management skills and lots of face time to resolve issues.
Cross-office consistency	Conchango’s tactics include shared-interest communities, investing time and money to ensure that it captures and develops best practices and intellectual property. Once every six weeks, agency personnel prioritize a “Community Day” over all other client commitments — as if it were a billable client project where projects are evaluated. Moreover, Conchango’s design teams are spread across a small geographic region, which minimizes the risk of inconsistency.
User experience	First site: 16 Second site: 24 Scores are based on a scale of -50 to 50.
Brand Image experience	First site: 10 Second site: 6 Scores are based on a scale of -12 to 12.
Satisfaction of reference clients	The average client satisfaction score is 3.88 on a five-point scale.

Source: Forrester Research, Inc.

Figure 1 Conchango Evaluation Overview (Cont.)**STRATEGY**

Clarity of vision	Conchango focuses on an integrated approach: investing the appropriate amount of time in user-centric design approaches; taking brand requirements into account; and understanding the technical implementation. It will focus on alternative devices and technologies by designing useable interactive kiosks and “smart” client applications, as well as using its experience in user-centered agile development practices.
Development of horizontal capabilities	Conchango identifies the following four areas as having the greatest impact on evolving Web design: mobile applications that will tap into the multichannel modes of working; Windows Vista; rich Internet applications (AJAX and Adobe Systems tool sets like Flash and Flex); and kiosks. The firm’s investment in kiosks should pay off if the technologies and techniques it uses become more relevant to Internet applications.
Development of vertical capabilities	Since 2000, Conchango has adopted a small number of verticals, developing the retail/CPG and financial services sectors so far and seeking at least one new sector. It focuses on long-term relationships, hires industry experts to develop the right skills, and establishes networks. This tactic seems to work: The agency has seen substantial revenue growth, of which 70% comes from repeat business.
Thought leadership	Conchango’s novel approach is substantiated by its participation on the Microsoft partner advisory council for the suite of professional design tools that are included in the Windows Presentation Foundation (WPF) and its continued investments in agile processes — it’s a member of the Agile Alliance and a UK leader in Agile project delivery, writing white papers and organizing Agile workshops.

MARKET PRESENCE

Billable staff as of Q1 2006	As of Q1 2006, Conchango dedicates 101 to 200 full-time equivalents to its site design practice.
Revenues (2005)	Estimated revenue from designing and building Web sites in 2005 is €15 million to €20 million.
Revenue growth (2004 to 2005)	Estimated revenue growth for the Web design practice in 2005 is more than 30%.
Number of European offices	Conchango has two European offices in the UK (Egham and London).

Source: Forrester Research, Inc.



Go online to download additional in-depth data and scores for this vendor and other vendors included in this Forrester Wave evaluation.

SUPPLEMENTAL MATERIAL

Online Resource

The underlying spreadsheet for Figure 1 is available online. The spreadsheet includes more detailed data and scores for this vendor.

This detailed data and scores for this vendor are also available online through an Excel-based vendor comparison tool that provides detailed product evaluations and customizable rankings.

The Forrester Wave Methodology

We conduct primary research to develop a list of vendors that meet our criteria to be evaluated in this market. From that initial pool of vendors, we then narrow our final list. We choose these vendors based on: 1) product fit; 2) customer success; and 3) Forrester client demand. We eliminate vendors that have limited customer references and products that don't fit the scope of our evaluation.

After examining past research, user need assessments, and vendor and expert interviews, we develop the initial evaluation criteria. To evaluate the vendors and their products against our set of criteria, we gather details of product qualifications through a combination of lab evaluations, questionnaires, demos, and/or discussions with client references. We send evaluations to the vendors for their review, and we adjust the evaluations to provide the most accurate view of vendor offerings and strategies.

We set default weightings to reflect our analysis of the needs of large user companies — and/or other scenarios as outlined in the Forrester Wave document — and then score the vendors based on a clearly defined scale. These default weightings are intended only as a starting point, and readers are encouraged to adapt the weightings to fit their individual needs through the Excel-based tool. The final scores generate the graphical depiction of the market based on current offering, strategy, and market presence. Forrester intends to update vendor evaluations regularly as product capabilities and vendor strategies evolve.

ENDNOTES

- ¹ Since 1998, Forrester has evaluated more than 600 sites with its Web Site Review methodology. See the October 4, 2005, Best Practices “[Best And Worst Of European Site Design, 2005](#).” Web sites must support both brand positioning and target user goals. See the June 9, 2005, Best Practices “[How Brands Succeed Online](#).”
- ² Firms like BrownCo estimate that testing with users from early stages of the process and fixing flaws before they are coded — even when timelines are tight — have helped them save as much as 25% of development time. See the March 31, 2006, Best Practices “[Culture And Process Drive Better Customer Experiences](#).”

- ³ Conversations with the crowd at KioskCom.com 2005 made one fact very clear about the state of kiosk evolution: Developers — not designers — are firmly in charge. The result? Firms' kiosk efforts are threatened by poor design processes, flawed usability testing, and a complete lack of vital upfront ethnographic research. To fix the problem and deliver better kiosks, vendors and buyers must open up to help from established usability and design firms. Buyers who don't have dedicated internal design resources should seek outside help from design firms with expertise in user-centered design. Specific experience in developing kiosks isn't strictly required, though having a successful track record with kiosks should put designers like frog design and Conchango at the top of buyers' lists. See the May 3, 2005, Best Practices "Kiosk Industry Flails For Usability."
- ⁴ Forrester evaluated 10 leading design agencies in Europe across 18 criteria and found that Conchango is the leader of the pack — thanks to its Web site design and corresponding brand-positioning capabilities and its user-centric design focus. AKQA and Agency.com are close behind. LB Icon and Wunderman are Strong Performers but lack some of the rigorous user research, testing, and development of personas that the Leaders display; Pixelpark, Creuna, and Satama Interactive just made it into this category: All three have work ahead to gain solid user insights and integrate this into their design process to beef up their current capabilities. FullSIX does solid user research and has a clear strategy but just falls into the Contender category because of a lack of persona creation and low user experience scores. Nurun came in last for the same reasons and lower scores on strategy. See the May 18, 2006, Tech Choices "The Forrester Wave™: European Web Design Agencies, Q2 2006."